

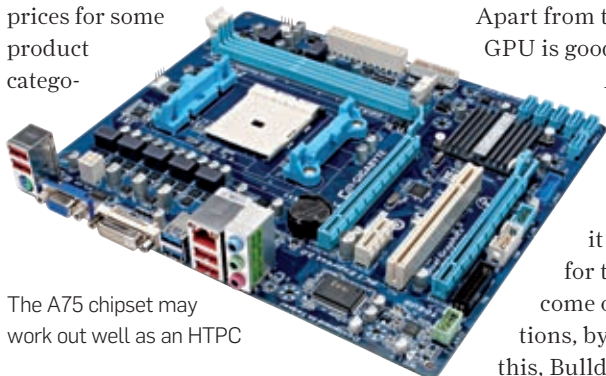
range of Atom processors to hit the scene. Look out for Atom Z670-based netbooks in the near future. Also, let's not forget the dark horse, AMD, in this department. A prudent choice is to go in for netbooks based on AMD's Fusion APU such as the C50.

SmartTVs or Idiot boxes?

This Diwali you're bound to find yourself inundated with offers on "Smart TVs" or products with identical nomenclature. At the most basic level, these networked TVs offer you nothing more than a few sources of web content via a wired LAN port. Instead of getting caught up in the fancy terminology, (much like 3D or LED) what you must think about is whether you have a home network in the first place. Remember, you'll need a spare LAN cable from your router to use the functionality of a Smart TV to the fullest. If your home setup fulfills this requirement, think about whether you're the type who will actively view web content on the TV. Also check out the exact sources of web content as it may not be of relevance to the Indian audience. Considering all this, you may not want to pay an exorbitant premium on these so-called Smart TVs. Of course, in the long term such TVs may be the way to go, but as of now does it makes sense buying them, is what you have to ask yourself.

Components

Most geeks also opt in for components to upgrade their rigs every Diwali. As per indicators, prices for some product categories can be predicted for a short term fairly accurately. For instance,

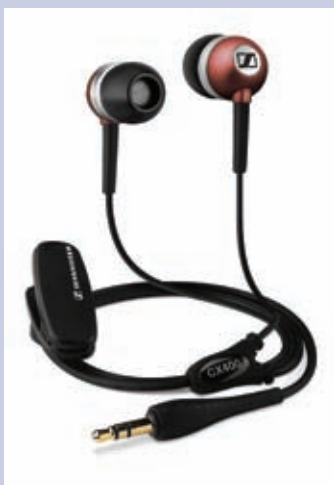


The A75 chipset may work out well as an HTPC

it's being said that RAM modules (DDR3 of course) are going to remain cheap till December.

Smart Tip

When buying headphones or in-ears, it's best to look for them online. In the offline world when you go to malls or big format retailers you have a very limited range to choose from. Most places will not stock the exact model that you desire. Most places won't even let



you demo the products, so what's the point of going to a physical store? Instead look for speciality audio gear at places such as primeabgb.com, lynx-india.com, and pristinote.com. Many of these online retailers have shops on eBay.in too.

Another popular category in components is building HTPC rigs. These rigs can also double up as download rigs and are usually paired with a large screen TV. In this space, currently going in for a Llano A75 chipset does make sense but only if you're not going to use it for processor-intensive tasks such as rendering or transcoding. Apart from these tasks, the on-board GPU is good enough for basic gaming.

Another nugget of information for the AMD fans to mull over in case you're thinking of going in for a Phenom II X6 processor, it could be prudent to wait for the Bulldozer range to come out. As per most estimations, by the time you're reading this, Bulldozer may already be out.

Cameras

Cameras are an evergreen segment, but purchases do spike in the shopping season. If you're willing to spend close to ₹35,000, it would be a good idea to look

at compact system cameras. Micro Four Thirds offer a lot more functionality over regular point-and-shoots, so much so that they're popularly called semi-dSLRs. Prices in this range are likely to go south and the entry of Nikon with its latest mirrorless 1J1 camera is an encouraging game-changer in this space.



Compact system cameras offer great functionality

All-in-one desktops

All-in-one (AIO) desktops may not be the most popular category with hardcore geeks, but these PCs find many takers with families. AIOs make good "home" PCs thanks to their attractive form factor and space-saving ability. These desktops are found at retail chains such as Croma or Ezone and many people opt for these. They're based on mobile chipsets similar to the mainboards found in laptops. One of the things to remember in this case is that you won't be able to easily upgrade components in the long run, so choose the specifications wisely. Also, some AIO desktops come with TV tuners which let them double up as TVs. Some models from Lenovo even let you view TV without booting into Windows, keep an eye out for such conveniences offered by some of the brands.

The last word

Hopefully, some of these tips will help you find your way to the smartest purchases of the season. After all, who doesn't want a bargain? Who doesn't want bragging rights for getting a steal and making the wisest purchase? Good wishes and happy shopping. 